

CHAPTER 7

GAMEPLAY IN DEPTH



CAMPAIGN SETUP SUMMARY

1

Create your character (page 193). Envision your character. Choose your name, set your stats, and select your assets. Refer to chapter 2 (page 31) for details. If you prefer, you can start by creating your world (below).

2

Create your world (page 194). If you are playing in the Ironlands, refer to chapter 4 (page 111) and the ‘Your Truths’ exercise (page 122). Otherwise, establish the basic truths of your own world. Envision where your story will begin and mark it on your map.

3

Create your background bonds (page 195). Mark up to three bonds to represent your connections to home, friends, family, or other loyalties. Make note of these bonds, and mark a tick for each.

4

Write your background vow (page 195). Create a sworn quest as backstory for your character. Write down this vow and give it a rank of extreme or epic. You don’t need to make the *Swear an Iron Vow* move for this quest.

5

Envision your inciting incident (page 196). Come up with the problem that drives your character into action.

6

Set the Scene (page 198). Decide whether you want to start with a prologue (the normal world), or in the midst of the problem (in media res). Envision the scene and begin play.

7

Swear an Iron Vow (page 199). Make the move and write down your vow. Give it a rank of troublesome, dangerous, or formidable.

8

Take your next steps (page 200). Based on the outcome of your *Swear an Iron Vow* move, envision what you do or what happens next. If you like, you may outline the milestones of your adventure. Then, play to see what happens.

THE MECHANICS AND THE FICTION

Ironsworn is a game. As such, it uses various **mechanics** to resolve situations and challenges. You make moves and roll dice. Your character uses stats, tracks, and assets as a representation of their abilities and readiness. The outcome of a move may have a mechanical impact, such as increasing your momentum track or reducing your health track. Managing your resources and making decisions based on a desired mechanical result is part of the challenge and fun of the game.

The **fiction** helps you define and understand your setting and your character. It guides your character's background, personality, and motivations. It provides a framework for the situations you face, the world you inhabit, and the people and creatures you encounter. As you play, you take actions through the imagined perspective of your character. The fiction helps inform what happens next.

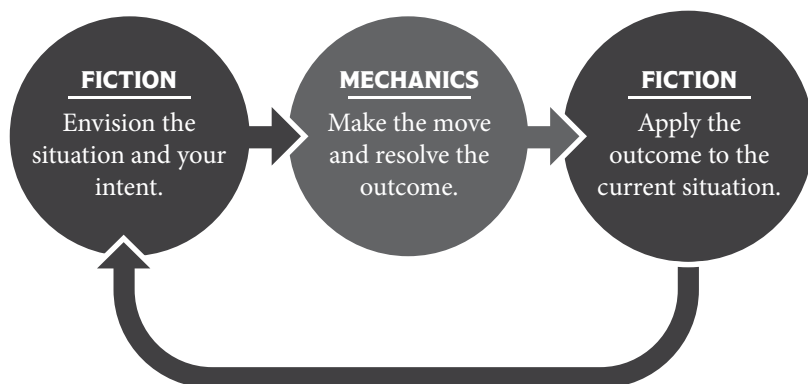
The intersection of fiction and mechanics is what makes the roleplaying experience vibrant and compelling. Think of the mechanics as your needle and the fiction as your thread. Using them both, you will weave the tapestry of your *Ironsworn* story.

LEADING AND FOLLOWING WITH THE FICTION

Without story, the game is an exercise in rolling dice. Without mechanics, your story lacks choices, consequences and surprises. An ideal session of *Ironsworn* leverages both the mechanics and the fiction, but leads and follows with the fiction.

What does that mean? Consider the fiction as the bookends to your moves. You start by picturing the situation. What is happening? What are you trying to do? How are you doing it? What opposes you? What complications might you face? If you are playing solo, envision it. If you are playing co-op, talk it out. If you are the GM, set the scene for your players and work with them to clarify any details.

Does the fiction trigger a move? If so, make it. Roll the dice. Deal with the mechanical outcome within the context of the current situation. If one of your status tracks—health, spirit, supply, or momentum—is adjusted as a result of a move, envision how this looks in the fiction. Don't just move the numbers around. Picture what it means for your character's readiness and well-being. Then, translate the result of your move back to the fiction. How does the situation change? What happens next?



FINDING YOUR BALANCE

The level of emphasis you give to the fiction varies by the situation and the desired pace of play. You can explore entire scenes—such as interactions with your allies and other characters—entirely through the fiction without engaging in moves. Other times, you may quickly gloss over the fiction to get on with things. That's fine. Use the mechanics of moves to portray the inherent drama and uncertainty of character intent and obstacles, but always look for opportunities to add texture and vibrancy to your world through the fiction.

You envision a quick scene as you return home and gather your gear. There's no move triggered here. You pack your supplies and don your armor. The mail shirt is heavier than you remember, as if weighed down by dark memories.

You stand at the door for a moment. Your hand rests on the hilt of your sword. "A blade never bloodied is a waste of iron," your mother once told you. You remember her words now, and say a quick prayer that your sword will not be drawn. It has seen enough blood.

Time is short. You must begin your quest.

FICTIONAL FRAMING

Ironsworn does not emphasize situational mechanics. Instead, the details are often abstracted within your moves and are reliant on **fictional framing**.

Think of it like moving a chess piece. Is it a pawn or a queen? What square is it on? What other pieces are on the board? What is the state of the game? All of these considerations impact the move you make and what happens next. There are rules. You can't simply decide to move a pawn three spaces or sweep the enemy pieces off the board.

Gameplay within *Ironsworn* is much less constrained than in chess, but is still framed by the rules of your narrative reality. Your actions and the events in your story need to make sense for the characters, the setting, and the fiction you have established through play. Your character's background, skills, beliefs, goals, and equipment all contribute to the actions you can take and how you envision those actions—even when those elements aren't defined by a stat or asset. NPCs don't have detailed mechanical attributes, but are portrayed as appropriate to the characteristics and intent you've established through play.

Fictional framing is your polestar. It helps create a character, a world, and situations which feel authentic and consequential.

How does fictional framing impact play?

- **It adds texture to your story.** Adding detail enriches your narrative, creates opportunities for new challenges and quests, and helps you visualize your character and your world.
- **It determines the moves you cannot make.** If you are not properly equipped or positioned to make a move, you can't do it. Without a very strong incentive, you can't *Compel* a hated enemy to help you.
- **It determines the moves you must make, or those you can avoid.** If you are unarmed and want to *Strike* a spear-wielding foe, you should *Face Danger* or *Secure an Advantage* to get in close. If you need information from someone and already have their trust and cooperation, you won't need to *Compel* them before you can *Gather Information*.
- **It guides the outcomes of your moves.** Look to the fiction when you have a question about the outcome of a move, especially when you *Pay the Price*. Do you suffer a mechanical result such as harm? Do you face a new narrative complication? If in doubt, *Ask the Oracle* and apply the context of your fictional framing to interpret the answer.
- **It helps determine the rank of your challenges.** The rank you give to your quests, journeys, and fights is influenced by the scope of the challenge within the fiction.

MANAGING YOUR QUESTS

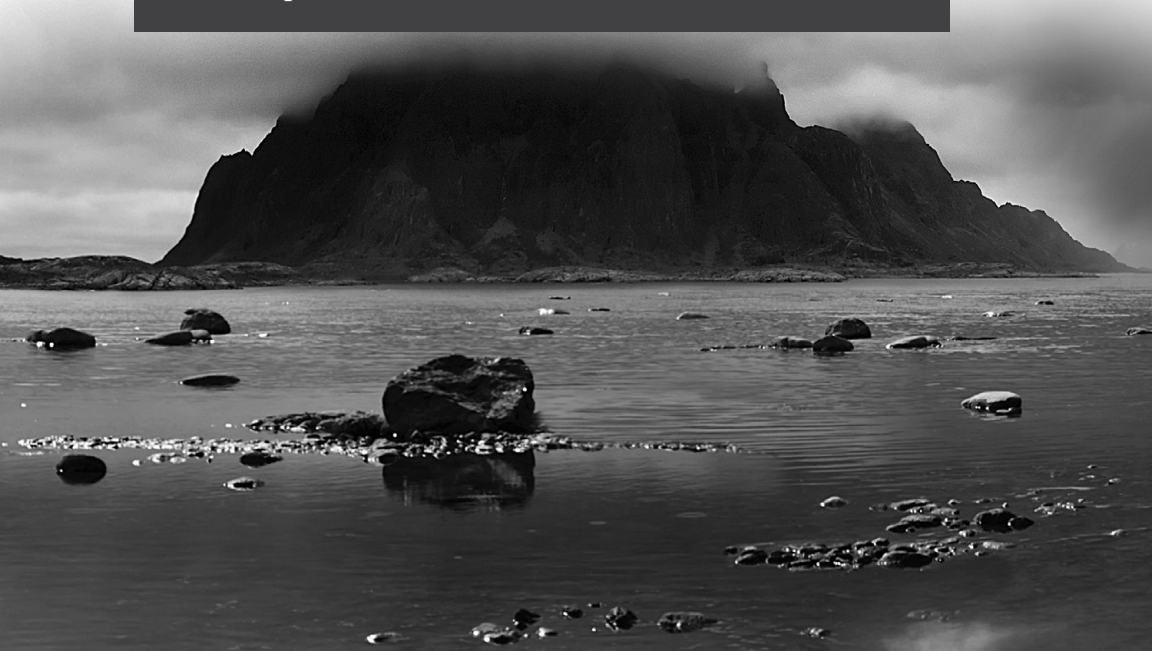
Sworn quests are the narrative engine of your *Ironsworn* adventures. When you start your campaign, your character has two vows: Your background vow (page 195), and a vow triggered by an inciting incident (page 196).

Making progress in these quests requires you to face and surmount obstacles. You will undertake perilous journeys, uncover information, gain the support of NPCs, recover important items, and defeat powerful foes. Your character will struggle to overcome their own limitations and find their preconceptions and loyalties challenged.

Putting these obstacles in your path isn't just for dramatic purposes. Succeeding against these trials, finding your way forward, enables you to reach milestones and mark progress on your quests.

In the fiction, an iron vow is a significant, deeply held promise. If a situation is not dramatic and relevant to your character's goals and principles, it's probably not worthy of a vow. It might be a milestone for a quest, or simply a narrative diversion as an opportunity for roleplaying or worldbuilding.

If you want to take on an Ironsworn quest, but the problem in front of you doesn't seem meaningful enough, punch it up. Give it context. Up the stakes.



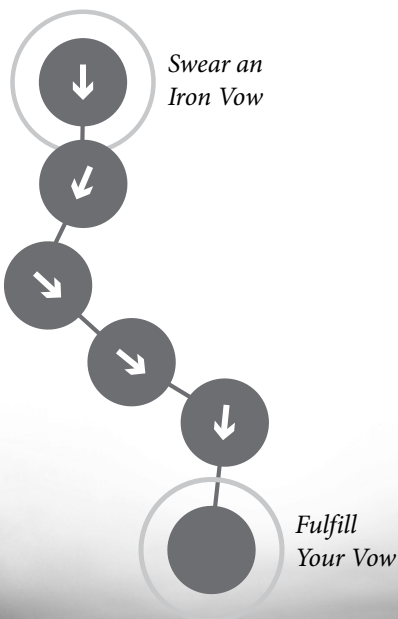
REACHING MILESTONES

Imagine your *Ironsworn* quest as a path of stones leading across the water. Each stone marks a major step forward—a milestone—triggering the *Reach a Milestone* move.

You might plan some of your quest milestones in advance (page 200). Others will emerge naturally from the fiction. The outcome of your moves or creative prompts may send your quest in unexpected directions, leading to new milestones and perhaps even new vows.

YOUR QUEST

Each major step forward triggers the *Reach a Milestone* move.



WHAT'S WORTHY OF A MILESTONE?

The text of the *Reach a Milestone* move states:

When **you make significant progress in your quest** by overcoming a critical obstacle, completing a perilous journey, solving a complex mystery, defeating a powerful threat, gaining critical support, or acquiring a crucial item, you may mark progress.

The pace of your quest will be largely defined by what you decide is “significant progress.” A milestone should accomplish two things:

- **It should relate directly to your quest.** A milestone should be meaningful to your character and your vow. An unrelated challenge which you deal with as you undertake your quest is probably not a milestone.
- **It should represent a turning point or major step forward in your quest.** Achieving a milestone requires effort and sacrifice for your character. A minor discovery or easy success is probably not a milestone, especially for a higher ranked quest. Not every step you take is a milestone.

MARKING PROGRESS

Your vows utilize a standard progress track (page 14) to measure how far you have come in your quest. This progress track is a mechanical representation of the likelihood of being successful when you *Fulfill Your Vow* (page 101). More filled boxes means a better chance of a hit on that move. The progress track also shows how much story potential you have fulfilled in your quest. Higher ranked vows require more focus in your story and more effort and sacrifice for your character.

When you *Reach a Milestone* (page 100), mark progress per the rank of your vow.

- **Troublesome quest:** Mark 3 progress.
- **Dangerous quest:** Mark 2 progress.
- **Formidable quest:** Mark 1 progress.
- **Extreme quest:** Mark 2 ticks.
- **Epic quest:** Mark 1 tick.

PRINCIPLES

These principles are your guideposts for managing your *Ironsworn* sessions. Much of this is redundant to the best practices discussed elsewhere in this rulebook. They are collected here to summarize core techniques, but you can adjust to your liking. It's your game. Start here, and find the path that leads you to awesome stories.

GENERAL PRINCIPLES

SWEAR IRON VOWS, AND SEE THEM FULFILLED OR FORSAKEN

Your sworn vows are the narrative framework of your *Ironsworn* stories. You will introduce an urgent problem or personal quest, *Swear an Iron Vow* to set things right, and play to see what happens. As you pursue your quest, you may encounter situations which take your vow in surprising directions or inspire new vows.

PORTRAY A HEROIC CHARACTER IN A HARSH LAND

The default tone of *Ironsworn* is heroic but grounded. Your character is exceptional, but you aren't a superhero or mythic figure. Add depth to your character by portraying them as a complete and imperfect person. You are flesh and blood. You will fail. You will get hurt. You will make mistakes. You will lose faith. You will act against your better instincts. Make decisions through the flawed perspective of this character.

You will also paint your world in shades of gray. The weather is hostile. Terrors lurk in dark nights and deep forests. Too often, Ironlanders fight and scheme amongst themselves instead of standing together against greater threats. But, there is beauty here. There is love and kinship. The people persevere.

Most of all, there is hope. The act of swearing a vow is an expression of that hope. Seeing it through—no matter the cost—is what makes you a hero.

BEGIN AND END WITH THE FICTION

Set every scene and action within the fiction. What is happening? What are you doing? What does it look like? If a move is triggered, make it. Then, look to the fiction to resolve the move and decide what happens next. Keep things moving forward, bookending the mechanics of your moves with the fiction.

Ironsworn rules, moves, and assets often use the term “envision.” This word is your reminder to visualize the scene or the action. Don't rush through your moves with a focus on the mechanical outcomes. Let your story breathe. Go

beyond the surface details. Ask questions (or *Ask the Oracle*), and build on the answers.

When playing with others, describing your character's intent and actions is part of the conversation you share at your table. When playing solo, take the time to imagine the scene and take note of important details.

To learn more about the fiction and fictional framing, see page 205.

SOLO PLAY

CHRONICLE YOUR ADVENTURES

When you play *Ironsworn* with other players, the shared conversation helps create a story that lives beyond the game table. As a solo player, your character and your world exist only for you. This can make your story feel a bit fleeting and unimportant.

To help ground your session, keep a record at whatever level of detail you prefer. This can be a few bullet points in a text file, a journal filled with sketches and notes, or even a detailed play report you share on a forum or blog. There's no wrong answer here. Use whatever approach works for you and is an enjoyable aspect of your play.

Creating a record also makes it easier to pick up where you left off when you return to the Ironlands.

ASK THE ORACLE, BUT TRUST YOUR INSTINCTS

Oracles are a valuable tool for solo play, but don't let them replace your own storytelling instincts. If it's dramatic, fits the fiction, and pushes your story forward, make it happen. Use oracles when you don't have an immediate answer to a question, or when triggered by a match.

The *Pay the Price* random table (page 105), in particular, isn't something you should roll on for every failure. Note the first option in this move: "Make the most obvious negative outcome happen." Let the result of your failed moves flow from the fiction. Make the occasional oracle roll for added uncertainty and surprise.

LET IT ALL FALL APART

As a solo player, you have control over the challenges you face and the outcomes of your actions. Don't let this control keep you from missing out on dramatic opportunities. A great story requires adversity. Failure makes success meaningful. When in doubt, err on the side of the dramatic, even (and especially) when it turns your character's life upside down or takes your story in an unplanned direction.

When you fail in a critical moment, make it hurt. Consider ways to represent this failure beyond shifting the value of one of your tracks. Take away something you cherish. Find yourself betrayed by someone you trusted. See your plans crumble. Narrative cost is a powerful storytelling tool.

PLAYING AS THE GM

DELIVER ANSWERS, OR TURN QUESTIONS BACK TO THE PLAYERS

If you are the GM, the players will look to you to answer questions about the world and help determine the outcome of moves. When they do, you can answer their question, keeping in mind the fictional framing you've established through play. If you see a chance to surprise or delight your players, take it.

You should also look for opportunities to facilitate conversations at your table. Encourage your players to add details and ground every move in the fiction. Answer a question by asking questions. Work to create a shared world and narrative which everyone has stake in. If a conversation hits a dead end or drags on, take the question back, deliver an answer (or *Ask the Oracle*), and move on.

FACILITATE, DON'T IMPOSE

You are the guide for your players as they explore the world and the story of their characters. You set the scenes and portray the creatures and characters they encounter. When the narrative hits a lull, you make something happen. But, you are a guide with a vague map and an unreliable compass. Let the players choose their path. Moderate the conversation without dominating it.

For campaign play, you facilitate character creation and worldbuilding to create the framework for your shared story. For a one-shot session (page 231), you can come prepared with a quest outline (page 200) to make the most of the limited time available. No matter what the format of your session, don't resist when everything goes completely and gloriously off-course.

EMBRACE CHAOS

Don't overprepare for your session. Feel free to come to the table with absolutely nothing planned. The character-driven quests help you and your players build a story together. Anything that is not a player character or move has very little mechanical detail, and can be introduced on the fly.

Letting go of your plans leaves you open to the unexpected. Cheer for surprising successes. Seize the story possibilities of dramatic failures. Listen to the players and let their suggestions inspire you.

You can also leverage the oracles for answers and inspiration. Ask a yes/no question through the *Ask the Oracle* move (page 107), or interpret an response from the oracle tables (page 167). You can even collaborate with your players to interpret an oracle's answer.